

Lawson leapfrog Yuki Tsunoda, a four-year F1 veteran. However, within the paddock, the decision came as less of a surprise.

What ultimately cast a shadow over the Japanese driver's Red Bull prospects was something beyond his control. With Honda, the unit's current engine supplier, set to switch to Aston Martin in 2026, his chances were slim. Despite shining in the RB20 during post-season testing, the team's attention had already shifted to the talented Kiwi, who has yet to complete a full F1 season.

A bold move

Red Bull has consistently given opportunities to drivers from its academy, barring the one-off move for Perez in 2021. The 22-year-old Lawson, who joined the junior programme in 2019, gradually climbed the ranks, spending two years each in F3 and F2.

The 2021 Abu Dhabi Young Driver Test helped him secure the AlphaTauri (now Racing Bulls) reserve seat for 2022, and ended up playing a dual backup role for both teams, a position he held into the following year. He finally made his debut in 2023, filling in for an injured Daniel Ricciardo for five races before eventually replacing him for the final six weekends of 2024.

Lawson got promoted after just 11 races, mirroring Red Bull's strategy

from 2016 when a 17-year-old Verstappen was promoted after just 23 races. That gamble paid immediate dividends, with Verstappen winning on his debut for the senior team and becoming the youngest race winner in F1 history.

The aggressive youngster may have taken his time to find his footing, but eventually delivered, with multiple wins and championships that solidified his status as the team's talisman. However, his rise marked the beginning of a carousel of second drivers after the departure of his closest competitor, Ricciardo, in 2018.

A double-edged sword

In his third season with Red Bull, Ricciardo partnered the Dutchman for 58 races (2016–18), a period that saw them often battle it out. The two were evenly matched in performance (608–590 points), but when it became clear to the Australian that his teammate was being prioritised more, he sought opportunities elsewhere.

Over the next two years, not every Red Bull promotion yielded the same success. Pierre Gasly was given a chance alongside his rapidly rising teammate in 2019 but crumbled under pressure, with Verstappen amassing almost three times the points of the Frenchman in 12 races (180–63).

After an underwhelming stint,

Gasly was demoted to Toro Rosso (now Racing Bulls), but an optimistic Red Bull handed the car to another rookie, Alexander Albon. The decision raised eyebrows, as the experienced Daniil Kvyat was overlooked — a driver who had previously been the sacrificial lamb in 2016 and was given only four races to prove himself.

The team showed more patience with Albon, who had just 12 races under his belt, granting him another season to shine. While he displayed flashes of his prowess over 26 races, he ultimately failed to match Verstappen's dominance (311–181). By 2021, however, Red Bull came across its perfect wingman in Perez.

The seasoned driver was pivotal in Red Bull's constructors' title campaigns and helped Verstappen secure his championships. But, in the end, even Perez began to struggle, especially against the much-improved McLarens and Ferraris. His declining performances in 2024 eventually led to the termination of a 90-race partnership (1861.5–932).

For Lawson, stepping into the Red Bull cockpit is both a golden opportunity and a trial by fire. But the challenge has more to do with his peer's relentless pace and consistency, leaving little room for error. While he may find solace in starting a new, full season with familiar faces around him, only time will tell if he's here to stay.

